



In 705 BCE, the Assyrian capital moved to Nineveh. This stone relief shows the Assyrian king and his queen feasting in the gardens of the royal palace there.

ASSYRIA CONTINUED ITS POLICY OF AGGRESSION through the 8th century BCE, conquering rival states in Western Asia and reducing them to provinces. Assyrian success was based on a **disciplined**, technically advanced **army** and an **efficient bureaucracy**. Conquered peoples had to pay costly tributes, and revolts were ruthlessly crushed. Particularly troublesome nations suffered forced deportations—large numbers of people were resettled in Assyria.

Following a period of weak rule in the first half of the 8th century BCE, Tiglath-Pileser III (r. 744–727 BCE) recouped Assyria's losses. His successor **Sargon II** (r. 722–704 BCE) campaigned in



Ritual container

Zhou smiths were highly skilled metalworkers. This bronze bowl dates from the 8th century BCE, the time of the Eastern Zhou dynasty.

Iran and Anatolia, conquering Babylon and, in 714 BCE, defeating the Armenian state of Urartu. He also defeated the Israelites and transported the “ten lost tribes” of Israel to northern Mesopotamia.

In **China**, the Zhou capital moved east to Luoyang in 770 BCE, marking the start of the earlier part of the **Eastern Zhou era**, which lasted until about 480 BCE (see 500 BCE). Royal control had weakened, as the lords who held large fiefdoms had grown more powerful. Now central control disintegrated, and **rival warlords** fought one another. Despite the chaos, this era was a time of technical and cultural advancement. Iron tools increased efficiency in agriculture and food production. Populations and cities grew, and **philosophy, the arts, and literature** began to develop. In Egypt, the unrest of the Third Intermediate Period continued. Since 850 BCE, the country had

been embroiled in a destructive civil war and was now divided into small states. In the 8th century BCE, the Kushite ruler of Nubia to the south, **Piye** (r. 747–716 BCE), **conquered** both Upper and Lower **Egypt**, and united them under **Kushite rule**.

In the Mediterranean, Phoenician influence continued to spread, as the city of **Carthage** in North Africa **grew powerful**. Greece, meanwhile, was starting to emerge from the Dark Age that had followed the Mycenaeans' downfall. City-states or **poleis** were forming on the Greek mainland, centered on hilltop citadels. To increase their territory, the **poleis** founded colonies around the shores of the Aegean. Although rivalry between cities was often intense, a **distinct Greek identity and culture** was emerging. All Greeks were identified as “Hellenes.” In 776 BCE the first pan-Hellenic games were held in honor of Zeus at **Olympia**. By the mid-700s BCE the Greeks had adapted the Phoenician alphabet

Twin discovery

This painting by Charles de La Fosse depicts the legend of Romulus and Remus, who were abandoned as babies and suckled by a she-wolf, before being rescued by shepherds.



Kushite statue

This alabaster statue dates from the period of Kushite rule in Egypt. Amenirdis I, sister of Shabaka (r. c. 716–702 BCE), is shown holding a flail—a traditional symbol of Egyptian rule.

for their own language, and not long after, Homer's epic poems the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*—hitherto transmitted orally—were probably written down.

In the 8th century BCE, **central Italy** was a mosaic of small states ruled by the dominant **Etruscans**—Italy's first indigenous civilization—and Italic tribes such as the Latins, Umbrians, and Sabines. **Rome** is thought to have been founded by the Latin chief **Romulus** in 753 BCE. In its early days, the city, built on seven hills, was ruled by various peoples, including the Etruscans, Latins, and Sabines.

“SUCH A GREAT TASK IT WAS TO FOUND THE ROMAN RACE.”

Virgil, from *Aeneid* 1:33



776 BCE First pan-Hellenic games held at Olympia in Greece, and every four years thereafter

c. 775 BCE Start of Greek colonization of Mediterranean

753 BCE Traditional date for founding of Rome by Romulus

c. 750 BCE Homer's Iliad and Odyssey written down

c. 744 BCE Tiglath-Pileser III of Assyria's reign begins (to 727 BCE)

714 BCE Sargon II defeats Urartu and sacks its major sacred site of Musuris

c. 722 BCE Sargon II takes Assyrian throne (to 705 BCE)

705 BCE Assyrian capital moves to Nineveh

701 BCE Assyrians invade Judaea